



For Staff

Nude and Semi-Nude Images Shared Without Consent

Responding when a student's intimate images are shared around the school, including where there are threats, blackmail or sextortion

Content Warning

This guide covers the sharing of nude and semi-nude images of children, sexual harassment, blackmail and sextortion.

This is reference guidance, not a training course. Use it to check how to respond, or to prepare for a conversation. It does not replace the school's safeguarding training, policy or the DSL's advice on a specific case.

It contains descriptions of intimate images of children being shared without consent, sexual harassment, blackmail and financially motivated sexual extortion ("sextortion"), and references to self-harm (without any detail of methods). No images are described. Some of it may be difficult to read, particularly if it connects with your own experience or that of someone close to you.

- You can read it in sections, take a break, or step away at any point.
- If this raises something personal, you can speak in confidence to your line manager, a senior colleague you trust, or the school's Employee Assistance Programme, if it has one, or **Education Support** (free, confidential, 24/7 on 08000 562 561). **Samaritans** is free and open any time, day or night, on 116 123.
- If you have a question about how this guidance applies to a situation you are dealing with, speak to your school's Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL).

If reading this makes you worried about a child now, do not wait until you have finished reading: speak to the DSL or a deputy straight away. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Immediate danger or possible risk to life: call 999 when it is needed, stay with the child, and summon the DSL or a deputy. Don't delay action to work through the steps. The 90-second Pause is for once immediate safety is secured, to stop an impulsive or investigative response. **Go to the Quick Reference Card.**

Why This Matters

When a young person's intimate image is shared without their consent, the harm spreads with every forward: fear, shame, isolation and harassment, often in front of the whole year group. Images are increasingly used to blackmail children. In 2025 there were **397 sextortion reports actioned by the IWF** (sexually coerced extortion involving child sexual abuse imagery), **a 127% increase on 2024**, and the IWF received **1,894 reports through Report Remove**, the Childline tool for under-18s, up 66% ([IWF, 2025](#); [IWF, 2025](#)).

KCSIE 2026 names the non-consensual making or sharing of nudes and semi-nudes, "especially around chat groups", as a way children abuse other children online (paragraph 23), lists consensual and non-consensual sharing as child-on-child abuse (paragraph 37), and requires a safeguarding response to **every** incident, consensual or not, proportionate to the age, development and circumstances of the children involved (paragraph 530), following the **UKCIS advice**. Staff should explain that "the law exists to protect children and young people, not criminalise them" (paragraph 557).

Scenario Overview

A Year 8 student reports that intimate photos they sent to their boyfriend have been shared around the school.

What to Keep in Mind

- **Tell the DSL immediately.** The UKCIS advice is that every incident goes to the DSL straight away, and the DSL leads from then on.
- **Never view, copy, forward, save or delete the images**, and never ask a student to show, send or delete them. This applies to every member of staff (UKCIS).
- **The student is not in trouble**, and is not to blame. Someone else chose to share the image.
- **Assume it is still spreading**, and that the student may be receiving comments, requests or threats. Ask about safety, including self-harm.

- **Several children are involved:** the student pictured, the boyfriend, and those who forwarded or received it. All need a safeguarding response planned by the DSL.
- **It may not be what it first looks like.** The "boyfriend" could be older, or an adult; the images could be altered or AI-generated; a threat or demand for money may follow. The DSL assesses this.

How RESPOND Works in This Scenario

RESPOND is powered by **ACT: Active Intervention** (inaction is not neutral; every forward adds to the harm), **Contextual Safeguarding** (the harm lives in group chats, peer groups and corridors, not only on one phone) and **Trauma-Informed Practice** (shame silences children; safety and dignity first). The steps are taught in order but work as a **helix**: see *The RESPOND Helix* section.

Step	RESPOND tool	In this scenario
● Recognise	4 Ps Context Scan; Escalation of Unseen Harm	Group chats, sharing, harassment, and signs of coercion, adults or blackmail
● Engage	TED questions; the disclosure script; 4Ds, if it is safe to do so	Believe them; no questions about what the images show; never look
● Support	Safety check first; "Your calm is contagious"	Self-harm risk, harassment today, and who has the images
● Pause	90-second grounding; Three Lenses (Risk, Rights, Resources)	Don't view, copy, delete, search, investigate or confront
● Offer	Model alternatives; if in doubt, N before O	You did the right thing; the law protects you; images can be removed
● Notify	DSL immediately; 999 for immediate danger	In person, now; the DSL holds the initial review
● Document	GOLD standard	Their words, who they said has the images, what you did; never describe an image

RESPOND is not a checklist to complete in order. Immediate danger or possible risk to life: act first (999 when needed, stay with the child, summon the DSL or a deputy), then return to the steps.

Need the essentials? The *Quick Reference Card* at the end of this guide covers the immediate response and escalation on one page.

The One Chance Rule: a disclosure may be a young person's only attempt to seek help. Make it count.

The RESPOND Helix: How the Steps Move

RESPOND is taught in a line, Recognise to Document, because sequence gives structure under pressure. In practice it moves as a helix. The first dimension is the steps themselves: you may loop back, hold at a step, or go straight to Notify. The second is time and severity: each turn sits higher as a concern develops. The third is context: a concern involving several children, places or platforms traces a wider spiral.

Relational and Systemic

For a child, safeguarding is **relational**: it happens through people they trust. For the adults around them, it is also **systemic**: the steps, records and shared decisions that make sure what a child tells one person reaches the people who can help.

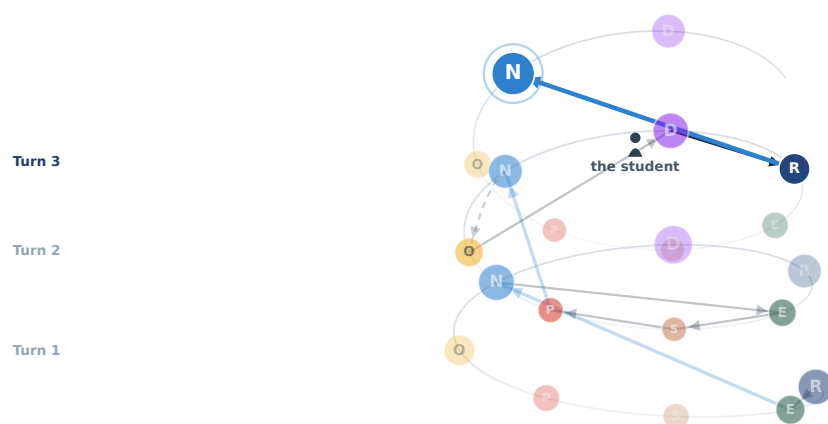
Relational is why children tell. Systemic is why telling works.

The RESPOND steps follow the same shape: Recognise, Engage and Support are relational; Pause is the bridge; Offer, Notify and Document are the systems steps. Neither works alone. Relationship without the system becomes secrecy, which is why staff never promise to keep a disclosure to themselves. The system without relationship becomes process that children do not trust enough to use. When you share information, be open with the child about what you are sharing and why.

See It Move

One example: a Year 8 student's photos shared around the year group, followed by a threat to send them to their family. Then see a wider spiral, where a group chat is involved, and what happens when steps are skipped.

This is a still image of the interactive RESPOND Helix. Open the web version of this guide to step through the examples; every example is also written out in full below.



▼ Read the helix demonstration as text

Sequence

How RESPOND is taught.

1. **The seven steps:** RESPOND is taught in this order, Recognise to Document, because sequence gives structure under pressure. Recognise, Engage and Support are the relational steps; Pause is the bridge; Offer, Notify and Document are the systems steps.
2. **But practice is not a line:** When a nude image has been shared, you go straight to Notify: the DSL leads from the first moment. The concern often keeps moving afterwards, to new chats, new platforms or a threat. Choose an example to see how the steps move.

An image shared

A Year 8 student's photos, sent to their boyfriend, are passed around the year group. The helix wraps around the student over two weeks.

1. **Turn 1: something is wrong:** A tutor notices a Year 8 student avoiding the form room while a group nearby goes quiet and laughs. Recognise: use the 4 Ps. You don't need a disclosure to act.
2. **Turn 1:** Engage: "Tell me how things are at the moment." The student says, "Everyone's seen something. I can't say." Don't push.
3. **Turn 1:** Notify and Document: tell the DSL the same day, and record what you saw and heard. The DSL may hold other pieces.
4. **Turn 2: the disclosure:** The next morning the student tells you that photos they sent to their boyfriend have been shared around the school. Engage: stay calm and use the script. "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault. I'm going to help keep you safe, and I'll explain what happens next."
5. **Turn 2:** Support: a private space and a safety check, including thoughts of self-harm. Don't ask what the photos show or to see anything.
6. **Turn 2: hold:** Pause for 90 seconds, then Three Lenses. Hold here on purpose: don't look at any phone, find the boyfriend or tell students to delete things.
7. **Turn 2: N before O:** Notify: the DSL, immediately and in person. The DSL holds the initial review and decides whether the police or children's social care need to know now.
8. **Turn 2:** Offer, once the DSL is involved: explain what happens next, that the law is there to protect them, and that Report Remove can help get images taken down.
9. **Turn 2:** Document: GOLD, as soon as is practicably possible. Their words and what you did. Never describe the images.
10. **Turn 3: a threat (ten days later):** An unknown account messages the student: it has the photos and will send them to their family unless they pay. Because the first concern was recorded, the DSL can link it.
1. **Turn 3: loop back:** Loop back to Recognise: this is now sexual extortion, possibly by an adult. Nobody waits to see if it happens again.
2. **Turn 3:** Notify and Document: the DSL, immediately; don't pay, reply or delete. The DSL contacts the police, and the record links to the earlier ones.

Wider spiral

Once an image reaches a group chat, several students are involved at once. One chat, three strands.

1. **Three strands:** The student pictured; the students who forwarded the image; and students who received it without asking. A single concern traces a tight spiral; this one is wider.
2. **At the same time:** Support the student pictured. Pause before any contact with the students who forwarded it: the DSL plans that. A student who received it is thanked and told not to show or forward it.
3. **Every strand notifies:** Every strand goes to the DSL, who decides about devices, deletion, parents and the police.
4. **Joined up:** Offer, once the DSL has decided: removal and support for the student pictured; accountability and learning for those who shared; reassurance for those who received it.
5. **Every strand:** Every strand ends in Document.

When it breaks

The same Year 8 student, when steps are skipped.

1. **Turn 1:** The student tells a teacher their photos have been shared. Recognise happens.
2. **Support skipped:** The adult says, "Why did you send them in the first place?" Nobody asks how they are. Support is skipped, and the student hears that it is their fault.
3. **Pause skipped:** The adult looks at a phone from the group, then tells the boyfriend to delete the photos. Pause is skipped: an image has been viewed, evidence may be lost, and the group knows who told.
4. **Notify and Document skipped:** Nothing reaches the DSL and nothing is recorded. When the threat arrives ten days later, there is nothing to connect it to.
5. **The helix fragments:** The student pays, and the demands continue. They have learned that telling makes it worse, and stop telling. That is how harm escalates unseen.
6. **Put it back together:** Every step taken puts the structure back. Relational is why children tell; systemic is why telling works.

The Helix is described in the RESPOND Safeguarding Operating System (section 5.2). All examples are fictional.

RECOGNISE: Identify the Harm and the Risk

Image-based abuse is often hidden by shame. Recognise what has happened, how far it has spread, and whether anything makes it more urgent.

The 4 Ps Context Scan

People

Who has the images? The boyfriend, friends, a group chat, older students, someone unknown? How old are they? Could an adult be involved?

Places

Where is the harassment happening? Form rooms, corridors, the bus, changing rooms, the boarding house. Where will the student be today?

Platforms

Group chats, disappearing messages, social media, sharing between nearby phones. Has it moved beyond the school?

Patterns

Is it spreading, or turning into threats, requests for more, or demands for money? Has this student, or this group, been involved before?

What It Can Look Like

Sharing Without Consent

- A student's image forwarded to friends, a group chat or another school, or posted online
- Sexualised names, comments or "jokes" aimed at one student

Pressure, Threats and Blackmail

- Pressure to send images, including from a partner
- Threats to share an image, or an old post or video, unless the student complies
- Demands for money, gift cards or more images: financially motivated sexual extortion ("sextortion")

Signs a Student May Be Affected

- Withdrawal, avoiding particular places or students, sudden absence or lateness

- Distress, fear or shame around their phone; changing accounts or numbers
- Being isolated or harassed by peers; a sudden change in how a group treats them
- Asking to borrow money, or a sudden need for money, with no clear reason
- Low mood, talk of everything being ruined, or signs of self-harm

No Disclosure Needed

If you overhear students talking about an image, see a phone being passed round, or notice the signs above, tell the DSL **without waiting for a disclosure** and without trying to find out more. A pattern can help explain what is happening, but you don't need to wait for it to happen again.

What Makes It More Urgent

- Any sign that an adult is involved, including someone who presented as a young person online
- Coercion, blackmail, grooming or threats, or demands for money or more images
- A student with SEND or other needs that may affect their capacity to consent
- Anything you are told suggesting a child under 13, or content unusual for the child's development or violent
- The student is distressed, self-harming or presenting as suicidal

These are the circumstances in which the UKCIS advice requires an immediate referral to the police or children's social care (UKCIS, section 2.3). You don't need to decide whether they apply: tell the DSL immediately.

What the Law Says (England and Wales)

- **Indecent images of children:** it is an offence to take, make, distribute or show an indecent photograph or pseudo-photograph of a child (Protection of Children Act 1978, section 1), and to possess one (Criminal Justice Act 1988, section 160). A child means anyone under 18, including the young person in the image. A pseudo-photograph is an image, "whether made by computer-graphics or otherwise howsoever, which appears to be a photograph" (section 7): digitally altered and AI-generated images can be covered. KCSIE 2026 says the same, including for AI-generated images (paragraph 540, footnote 145).
- **Intimate image abuse:** since 31 January 2024 it has been an offence to share a photograph or film that shows, or appears to show, another person in an intimate state without their consent, and to **threaten** to share one, intending the person to fear the threat will be carried out or being reckless about it (Sexual Offences Act 2003, section 66B, inserted by the Online Safety Act 2023).
- **Blackmail:** an unwarranted demand with menaces, with a view to gain or intent to cause loss, such as demanding money not to share an image (Theft Act 1968, section 21).
- **Criminal responsibility** in England and Wales starts at 10 (GOV.UK), so the criminal law applies to students of any secondary age.

Why the Law Should Reassure, Not Frighten

- The law was written to protect children from adults who abuse them, not to criminalise them. A criminal justice response against a child is considered only in exceptional circumstances (UKCIS, section 1.9).
- If the police are told, they must record a crime, but where there is no exploitation, grooming, profit motive, malicious intent or persistent behaviour they can record "Outcome 21" (further action not in the public interest). Recording is not a criminal record (UKCIS, section 1.9; College of Policing), though an Outcome 21 record could, rarely, be disclosed on an enhanced DBS check (UKCIS, section 1.9(c)). That is a police decision.
- RSHE teaches that students "will not be in trouble for asking for help, either at school or with the police, if an image of themselves has been shared" (RSHE statutory guidance, online safety and awareness). Say this to the student.

Staff never decide whether an offence has been committed, or whether an image is "indecent": that is for the courts. Describe what you were told and report it to the DSL. Legal references checked 28 September 2026.

What the Data Shows

397

sextortion reports actioned by the IWF in 2025, across all its reporting routes (sexually coerced extortion involving child sexual abuse imagery), up 127% on 2024

IWF, 2025

92%

of the IWF's sextortion reports over the last three years (a wider, three-year group of reports) involved boys

IWF, 2025

1,894

reports to Report Remove from UK under-18s in 2025, up 66% on 2024

IWF, 2025

50,000+

reports of financially motivated sextortion to the US National Center for Missing & Exploited Children in 2025 (global)

NCMEC, 2026

IWF figures are for reports it assessed and actioned, not the total number of children affected. NCMEC receives reports from across the world. Checked 28 September 2026.

E

ENGAGE: Listen, Believe, Don't Look

Your first words decide whether they keep telling. Stay calm, believe them, and never ask what the images show.

What a Student Might Say

"I sent some pictures to my boyfriend and now everyone's got them. Please don't tell my parents. Am I going to get arrested?"

The RESPOND disclosure script:

"I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault. I'm going to help keep you safe, and I'll explain what happens next."

- **Thank them:** "Thank you for telling me. That took courage, and it was the right thing to do."
- **Answer the fear:** "You're not in trouble for telling me. The law is there to protect young people, not to get them into trouble."
- **TED, only as much as you need:** "Tell me what's happening now." "Explain who you think has seen them." "Describe how you're feeling." Never "why": "why did you send it?" is the question that silences children (UKCIS, section 2.5).
- **Ask about pressure and threats:** "Has anyone asked you for more, or said they'll do something unless you do what they want?"
- **Don't ask about the content,** and don't take or look at a phone. If the student starts to show you, stop them kindly: "You don't need to show me. I believe you."

Helpful

- "This isn't your fault. Someone else chose to share it."
- "There are ways to get images taken down."
- "You don't have to sort this out on your own."

Unhelpful

- "Why did you send it?" or "What did you expect?" (blame)
- "Show me what was sent." (viewing an image is not your role, and can be an offence)
- "Just delete it and it'll go away." (loses evidence, and it won't)
- "I won't tell anyone." (a promise you can't keep)

- "You'll be in serious trouble with the police." (frightening and inaccurate)

If a Student Tells You They Received an Image

- **Thank them**, and reassure them they are not in trouble for telling you.
- **Don't look at it**, and don't ask them to show, forward or delete it. Ask them not to show or send it to anyone.
- Note who they said sent it, and where, and tell the DSL now.

If You See an Image Being Passed Round

Act if it is **safe to do so**, using the 4Ds: **Direct** ("Phones away, now, please"), **Distract** (move the group on), **Delegate** (send for the DSL or a senior colleague), **Delay** (check in privately with the student pictured afterwards). Don't look at the screen. If a device is handed to you, don't look at it: follow the school's confiscation policy, keep it secure and take it straight to the DSL. If you see an image by accident, tell the DSL and ask for support.



SUPPORT: Safety First

Safety comes first: their wellbeing now, what they will face in school today, and whether anyone is threatening them. Your calm is contagious.

Safety Check

Wellbeing

- "How are you feeling right now?"
- "Sometimes when something like this happens, people think about hurting themselves. Have you had thoughts like that?"

Today

- "Is anyone saying things to you in school?"

- **Online:** "Is anyone messaging you about it, asking for more, or asking for money?"

If They Have Thought About Hurting Themselves

- **Stay with them.** Send another adult for the DSL; don't leave them alone.
- Don't ask about methods. The DSL leads the risk assessment and the route to mental health support.
- If their life may be at risk, or they cannot keep themselves safe, call 999. Presenting as suicidal or self-harming is one of the UKCIS criteria for immediate referral.

Immediate Practical Support

- A private, quiet space away from the group; the option not to go back to lessons straight away
- Let them keep their phone unless the DSL decides otherwise; don't take it, look through it, or ask them to delete anything
- Agree who they will be with at break, lunch and home time

SEND, Neurodivergence and Language

- Some students with SEND may be more easily pressured, find it harder to recognise manipulation, or not understand where an image could go. Concern about capacity to consent is a trigger for immediate referral (UKCIS, section 2.3).
- Use clear, concrete words and allow processing time.
- Use a professional interpreter where language is a barrier, never another student or a family member.

Support for Everyone Involved

The Student Pictured

- Reassurance that they are not alone and will be kept informed
- Help to get images removed (Report Remove, Take It Down, platform reports)
- Protection from harassment and a named adult

Students Who Received It

- Thanks, and reassurance for anyone who told
- Advice not to share it further; the DSL decides about deletion

Students Who Shared It, Including the Boyfriend

- Learning about consent, trust and the law, including for altered or AI-generated images
- Consequences under the behaviour policy, and support: some who share have been pressured or harmed themselves
- Specialist help where there is a pattern of harmful sexual behaviour, such as Shore (Lucy Faithfull Foundation): anonymous advice for teenagers worried about their own sexual behaviour online or offline, including sharing nudes, at shorespace.org.uk

P

PAUSE: Consider Your Approach

Take 90 seconds: breathe, lower your shoulders, check your own state. The urge to see how bad it is or find the phones is strong: Pause is where you stop.

Three Lenses

Lens	In this scenario
Risk	Is the student safe now, including from self-harm? How far has the image spread? Is there coercion, a threat, a demand for money, an older student or an adult? Is the student under 13, or do they have SEND?
Rights	The student's right to privacy, dignity and a say in what happens; the rights of the other children involved, who are also children and need a fair and safeguarding response
Resources	The DSL, the pastoral team, counselling, the police and children's social care, Report Remove and Take It Down, and the safe adults in the student's life

What You Must Not Do

Don't View, Copy or Delete

- **Never view, copy, print, share, store or save an image**, or ask a child to share or download it. This is illegal.
- **Don't delete it, or ask anyone to delete it.** Any later deletion is a DSL decision.
- Viewing is exceptional, **for the DSL only**, and only where it is unavoidable, such as when it is the only way to decide whether to involve other agencies (UKCIS, section 2.10). It is never for other staff.

Don't Investigate

- Don't search phones, bags or group chats. Only the headteacher, or staff they authorise, can search a student or their device, and only under the DfE searching guidance.
- Don't question the other students about the images; that is the DSL's role.
- Don't discuss it with other staff, students or parents beyond the DSL.

Don't Confront

- Don't speak to the boyfriend or the students sharing it, or tell them to delete it
- It can spread the image further, lead to evidence being lost, and put the student at risk

Don't Promise Secrecy or Outcomes

"I can't keep this between us, because I want to keep you safe. I'm going to speak to the DSL now, and only people who need to know will be told. We'll talk with you about how your parents are told."

- Don't promise the images will disappear, or that parents won't be told

Check Your Own Response

- Notice any judgement about the student sending an image, and put it aside. Victim-blaming stops other children coming forward.
- If you have seen an image by accident, tell the DSL and ask for support; this is distressing, and it is not your fault.
- Afterwards, look after yourself. Education Support: 08000 562 561, free, confidential, 24/7, for education staff.



OFFER: Model Alternatives

Offer proportionate options without coercion, explain what happens next, and model a different response to image-based abuse. If in doubt, N before O: here the DSL is involved before you offer options.

Explain What Happens Next

"Here's what happens now. I'm going to get our safeguarding lead, and I'll stay with you until they're here. No one here will ask you to show them your photos, and staff won't copy or share them. The DSL will talk with you about getting them taken down, and about how your parents are told. If the police are involved, it is to protect you. Please don't delete anything or reply to anyone for now. None of this is your fault. What questions do you have?"

Be honest about information sharing. Staff should share safeguarding information as early as possible, and data protection law does not prevent it; safeguarding children is a lawful basis for sharing sensitive information without consent where appropriate (KCSIE 2026, paragraphs 142 to 148). What is shared must be relevant, necessary and proportionate, go only to those who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. From 30 September 2026, the Information Sharing Duty (section 16LA, Children Act 2004) also requires the organisations it covers to share where its tests are met; the DSL decides how it applies. So don't ask for consent as if it were the legal basis. Tell the student what will be shared, with whom and why, unless that would increase the risk, and listen to their views: they shape the plan. Agreeing to a service, such as counselling, is a separate question, and their agreement matters there.

Options, Not Orders

- "Would you like me to stay while you talk to the DSL?"
- "Would you like to be there when your parents are told, or would you rather we start the conversation?"

The UKCIS advice says the young person should be given a sense of control over the reporting process (section 2.5). Some things must happen, such as telling the DSL; where there is a choice, give it to them.

Model the Alternative

Safer Responses

- Tell a trusted adult, as they have
- Don't reply, pay or send anything more to anyone making threats
- Keep messages; don't delete them for now
- Use Report Remove to get images taken down

Responses That Make It Worse

- Paying or sending more to make threats stop
- Messaging the people who shared it, or asking friends to find out who has it
- Deleting everything and saying nothing

Removal and Reporting Routes (the DSL Decides Who Reports What)

- Report Remove (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation): for under-18s in the UK, to report a nude or sexual image or video of themselves and try to get it removed from the internet, at childline.org.uk. You need a Childline account, and Childline counsellors can support you.

- Take It Down (run by the US National Center for Missing & Exploited Children): for anyone under 18, anywhere, including the UK, if a nude image of them has been or might be shared online. It makes a digital fingerprint of the image on the device, so the image is not uploaded, and it works only with the platforms that take part, not on encrypted services: takeitdown.ncmec.org. UKCIS suggests it particularly where an image has not yet been shared but the young person has been threatened.
- Platform reporting tools; where a platform has no public reporting route, adults can report to the Internet Watch Foundation (UKCIS, section 2.12).
- CEOP Safety Centre (National Crime Agency): ceop.police.uk, to report online sexual abuse, grooming or sexual blackmail. It cannot deal with bullying, fake accounts or hacking. If someone is in immediate danger, call 999.

Support in School and Beyond

- Counselling or pastoral mentoring; a daily check-in with a named adult at first
- RSHE on consent and victim-blaming, planned so it does not single out the student
- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at childline.org.uk (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest)
- Shout: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- Samaritans: 116 123, free, any time, day or night

N

NOTIFY: Report the Concern

Tell the DSL as soon as is practicably possible. For shared nude images, the UKCIS advice is that this means immediately, in person. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Who and When

- Send a colleague or use the school's urgent system: "I need the DSL now. A student has told me intimate images of them are being shared."
- If the DSL is not available, go to a deputy. If neither can be reached, go to a senior leader, or take advice from children's social care (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 61). Don't wait until the end of the lesson or the day.
- Anyone can refer directly to children's social care if they believe a child is at risk; telling the DSL does not remove your own responsibility.

What to Tell the DSL

- Who the student is, where they are now, and who is with them
- What they said, in their words, including who they think has the images and where they have been shared
- The age of the boyfriend and others involved, if known; any sign of an adult, pressure, threats or demands
- How the student is, including anything they said about self-harm
- Whether any device was handed to you, and where it is now; whether you saw anything by accident

▼ For the DSL: assessment, external agencies and parents

Most staff need only: tell the DSL, today, with the information above.

The DSL's Initial Review (UKCIS, sections 2.1 to 2.4)

- Hold an initial review with appropriate staff: immediate risk; whether to refer; who created the images (including whether altered or AI-generated); how widely and where they have been shared; and whether they should be removed from devices or online services
- **Refer immediately** to the police or children's social care if: an adult is involved; there is reason to believe a child was coerced, blackmailed or groomed, or there are concerns about capacity to consent (for example, owing to SEND); what you know suggests content unusual for the child's development, or violent; the images involve sexual acts and any child in them is under 13; or a child is at immediate risk of harm, for example presenting as suicidal or self-harming
- Where none applies, the DSL may manage the incident in school, but only when confident the risks can be managed, with input from the headteacher; record the decision and the reasons, and review it as more is learned. Images shared without consent and with malicious intent, or used to bully or blackmail, should be referred to the police (UKCIS, Annex B)
- Do not view images unless it is unavoidable (section 2.10): the decision is discussed with the headteacher or a senior leader, viewing is by the DSL (or delegated safeguarding team member) with another member of staff present who does not view, on school premises, ideally by a staff member of the same sex as the child, and recorded. Never copy, print, share, store or save an image
- Where devices must go to the police: confiscate them, disconnect them from Wi-Fi and data, turn them off, and lock them away until collected. Any search of a device follows the DfE searching guidance; deletion is considered only where other agencies are not involved, and is recorded (section 2.10)
- Talk with the children involved: ideally the DSL, or a member of staff the student prefers, supported by the DSL (section 2.5)

- Where the police are involved, agree with them what is said to the other children's families, and when, before any contact (KCSIE 2026, paragraphs 599 and 603)
- Where the Information Sharing Duty applies (from 30 September 2026), apply its three tests: share information that is relevant to safeguarding or promoting the child's welfare (Relevance) and may help the recipient to safeguard or promote their welfare (May facilitate), unless sharing would be more detrimental to the child than not sharing (Detriment), which applies only in extremely limited circumstances; record the decision to share or not share, with the rationale, and be transparent with the young person unless that would increase the risk. Data protection law still applies to how information is shared
- Record every decision, including decisions not to refer, signed off by the headteacher; never attach copies of images (section 2.11)

When to Involve Other Agencies

Agency	When
Police (999 or 101)	Any of the immediate referral criteria; sharing without consent with malicious intent; blackmail or sextortion (101, or 999 if there is a threat to life); devices that need to be seized
Children's social care	Significant harm or risk of it; concerns at home; a child already known to them
CEOP (National Crime Agency)	Online sexual abuse, grooming or sexual blackmail, alongside the police. Not for bullying, fake accounts or hacking

For sextortion, see also the NCA alert for education settings (listed in KCSIE 2026, Annex A).

Where a Student Is 18

At 18 a student is legally an adult. The child safeguarding framework in KCSIE applies to under-18s, but the school still has welfare responsibilities. Where an 18-year-old is involved, the DSL considers adult safeguarding, police and welfare pathways alongside the school's procedures, and the adult student's own views and consent in a different way. This matters in sixth form and in boarding, where students turn 18 during their final year.

Before Contacting Parents or Carers

Parents and carers should be told at an early stage and involved, **unless there is good reason to believe that would put the child at risk of harm** (UKCIS, sections 2.1 and 2.6). That could be abuse at home, or cultural, religious or family factors affecting how they or their community would respond (Annex B). A decision not to inform parents is made with children's social care or the police, who lead on when they are told, and the reasons are

recorded. Where possible, support the student to be part of telling their parents. Anything said to other families is agreed by the DSL, and with the police where they are involved.

Parent contact: the student pictured

- "We need to talk to you about [name]. Some private images of [name] have been shared by other students without their consent. [Name] came to us, which was exactly the right thing to do, and they are safe and with us now."
- "Please don't look at, save or forward any images, and try not to be angry with [name]. We will help with getting the images removed."

Parent contact: a student who shared an image

- "We need to talk to you about [name]'s involvement in sharing an image of another student. This is serious, and we are following our safeguarding and behaviour procedures."
- "Please don't look at, delete or forward anything on [name]'s phone until we have agreed next steps. We also want to make sure [name] gets support."

D

DOCUMENT: Record Observations

Record as soon as is practicably possible, on the school's safeguarding system, using **GOLD**. Every incident is recorded, including those not referred on. Record what you were told; never describe, copy or attach an image.

GOLD

Ground

Date, time, place, who was present, who you are, and how it came to your attention

Observe

What you saw and heard, with exact words in quotation marks

Language

Neutral, factual and non-diagnostic. No opinions or labels

Do

What you did, what you said
would happen next, and why

Example: Exact Words

- Student said: "I sent some pictures to my boyfriend and now everyone's got them."
- Student said: "He said he only showed his mate, but it's in the Year 8 chat now."
- When asked whether anyone had asked for more or made threats, student said: "No, not yet."
- I did not view any image. No device was handed to me.

Recording template

SAFEGUARDING CONCERN: NUDE OR SEMI-NUDE IMAGES SHARED

Date and time:

Student: name, year, tutor group

Recorded by: name and role

Where and how it came to your attention:

WHAT THE STUDENT SAID (exact words in quotation marks):

WHO THEY SAID HAS THE IMAGES, AND WHERE SHARED (as told; names, chats, platforms):

AGES OF OTHERS INVOLVED, IF KNOWN; ANY SIGN OF AN ADULT:

PRESSURE, THREATS, DEMANDS FOR MONEY OR MORE IMAGES: yes / no / as told

SELF-HARM: what I asked, and what the student said

IMAGES: I did / did not see an image (if seen by accident, say so; never describe it)

DEVICES: any handed to me, and where they are now

OBSERVATIONS (presentation, emotional state):

WHAT I DID AND SAID (with times):

SHARED WITH: DSL (name, time, how)

THE STUDENT'S WISHES AND VIEWS:

Signed and dated:

What Not to Record

- Any description of what an image shows; copies, screenshots or attachments
- Opinions about the student's choice to send an image, or labels for any student

Online Context: Group Chats, AI Images and Sextortion

An image shared in the evening is in every corridor by morning.

Group Chats and Peer Groups

Once an image reaches a group chat it can reach other chats, schools and platforms in minutes. Receiving an image unasked is not the same as forwarding it. The DSL responds to the whole chat and peer group, and considers whether other schools need to be told.

Altered and AI-Generated Images

KCSIE 2026 defines nudes and semi-nudes to include images that are "digitally altered or wholly generated using artificial intelligence", and lists explicit images generated using AI among the online "conduct" risks (KCSIE 2026, Terminology; paragraph 165). The harm is real whether or not the image is. Never ask a student to prove it is fake; treat it as any other incident (UKCIS, section 2.5). Altered or AI-generated images of a child may be indecent images: don't decide their legal status yourself.

Sextortion and Blackmail

Financially motivated sexual extortion is usually carried out by organised criminal groups, often overseas, who pose as young people or use hacked accounts, then threaten to share real or altered images unless the child pays (UKCIS, Annex A). Children can also blackmail each other. The NCA advises: **don't pay, stop contact and block, don't delete evidence, and report** (NCA). Tell the DSL immediately. Staff Guides 44 (online blackmail) and 88 (sextortion) cover these in detail.

Staff who need advice on removal or an online incident can contact the Professionals Online Safety Helpline.

Boarding and Residential Life

For boarders, school is also home, and threats often arrive at night.

Step	In boarding
● Recognise	Use the 4 Ps for the house: images and threats often arrive late in the evening, and house group chats spread them fast. Notice a boarder on their phone late at night or suddenly needing money.
● Engage	Boarders often tell house staff at informal times. Use TED and the script; never look at a device.

Step	In boarding
● Support	Safety tonight comes first: if there is any self-harm risk, the DSL plans overnight checks with the duty team. Agree with the DSL what happens to devices at night; taking a phone can feel like punishment, and it may be evidence.
● Pause	Those involved may live in the same house. Don't search rooms or phones or speak to the boarders involved; follow the DSL's plan for keeping them apart.
● Offer	Model alternatives: house expectations on sharing and phones at night. If in doubt, N before O.
● Notify	Contact the on-call DSL immediately, including at night: shared images, threats and sextortion can involve immediate risk. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.
● Document	Record on the safeguarding system before you go off duty, using GOLD. A house log or handover note is not a substitute.

Boarders' Routes to Help

- **Boarders can always contact their house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.** Make sure every boarder knows how.
- An independent person outside the staff whom boarders can contact directly (NMS 11.4), often called the independent listener
- Boarders must be able to contact their families privately; monitoring of communications should be proportionate (NMS 12.1)
- International boarders: agree with the DSL who contacts parents or guardians, when, and in what language, using interpreters where needed

Source: National Minimum Standards for Boarding Schools (2026).

International boarders may be targeted from other time zones, and the DSL agrees how and in what language parents or guardians are told.

Identity and Intersecting Harm

Who a student is shapes the harm, the risk and the barriers to telling.

- **Girls** are more likely to be victims of sexual harassment (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 532), and often face slut-shaming and victim-blaming when images are shared. The UKCIS advice asks schools to challenge victim-blaming (section 3.3).

- **Boys** are the main targets of sextortion (IWF, 2025), and may feel less able to ask for help. The NCA found most boys it surveyed did not understand sextortion or know how to report it (NCA, 2025).
- **LGBTQ+ students** may fear being outed as well as exposed. The DSL weighs this when planning parent contact.
- **Disabled children** are three times more likely to be abused than their peers (KCSIE 2026, paragraph 532).
- **Faith and culture:** some students may fear serious consequences at home, in some cases so-called honour-based abuse. The DSL considers this before parents are told.

Additional Resources and Support

For Students

- Childline (for anyone under 19): 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at childline.org.uk (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest). **For under-18s, this is the place to start.**
- Report Remove (under-18s): childline.org.uk
- Shout: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- Shore (Lucy Faithfull Foundation): anonymous advice for teenagers worried about their own sexual behaviour online or offline, including sharing nudes, at shorespace.org.uk

For Parents and Carers

- NSPCC Helpline: 0808 800 5000 (Monday to Friday 10am to 4pm), or help@nspcc.org.uk
- YoungMinds Parents Helpline: 0808 802 5544 (Monday, Thursday and Friday 9:30am to 4pm; Tuesday and Wednesday 9:30am to 6pm)
- Parent Guide 10 (shared with Scenarios 44 and 88)

For Staff

- Education Support: 08000 562 561, free, confidential, 24/7, for education staff
- Professionals Online Safety Helpline (UK Safer Internet Centre): helpline@saferinternet.org.uk, Monday to Friday, for anyone working with children

- CEOP Safety Centre (National Crime Agency): ceop.police.uk, to report online sexual abuse, grooming or sexual blackmail. It cannot deal with bullying, fake accounts or hacking. If someone is in immediate danger, call 999
- National Crime Agency CEOP Education, *Financially motivated sexual extortion: alert for education settings*
- National Crime Agency, *Sextortion* (advice for victims and parents)

Statutory Guidance and Law

- Department for Education, *Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026*
- HM Government, *Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026*
- Department for Education, *Information Sharing Duty: statutory guidance* (in force 30 September 2026)
- UKCIS, *Sharing nudes and semi-nudes: advice for education settings working with children and young people* (updated February 2024)
- Department for Education, *Searching, screening and confiscation* (guidance for schools)
- Department for Education, *RSHE statutory guidance* (published July 2025; statutory from September 2026)
- Department for Education, *National minimum standards for boarding schools* (2026)
- Protection of Children Act 1978, section 1 (indecent photographs and pseudo-photographs of children)
- Sexual Offences Act 2003, section 66B (sharing or threatening to share an intimate photograph or film), inserted by the Online Safety Act 2023
- Theft Act 1968, section 21 (blackmail)

Figures

- Internet Watch Foundation, *Annual Data and Insights Report 2025: sexually coerced extortion*
- National Center for Missing & Exploited Children, *New sextortion data: 2025* (25 June 2026)

Contacts, figures and legal references checked 28 September 2026. Verify at point of use.

Quick Reference Card

Immediate Danger Comes First

Immediate danger or possible risk to life: call 999 when it is needed, stay with the child, and summon the DSL or a deputy. Don't delay action to work through the steps. The 90-second Pause is for once immediate safety is secured, to stop an impulsive or investigative response.

Recognise

- Images passed round, sexualised comments, a student suddenly isolated
- More urgent: an adult, coercion, threats, money, SEND, under 13, self-harm
- No disclosure needed; don't wait for it to happen again

Respond

- "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault."
- You're not in trouble; the law is there to protect you
- Never view, copy, forward, save or delete; never ask to see
- Don't search, investigate, confront or promise secrecy

Notify

- DSL immediately, in person; stay with the student
- DSL unavailable: a senior leader, or advice from children's social care
- Immediate danger or life at risk: 999

Document

- GOLD: Ground, Observe, Language, Do
- Their words; who has the images and where, as told
- Never describe or attach an image

Emergency, DSL, Police: Three Different Things

- **Immediate danger or risk to life:** 999 now, stay with the student, then the DSL.
- **Every case:** the DSL, immediately. The DSL leads the response; you don't decide about police.

- **Police referral is not optional** where intimate images are involved and any of these apply: an adult is involved; the young person has been coerced, blackmailed or groomed, or there are concerns about their capacity to consent (for example, SEND); the content is unusual for their developmental stage, or violent; sexual acts and a child under 13; or immediate risk of harm, such as suicidal thoughts or self-harm. The DSL makes an immediate referral to the police and/or children's social care (UKCIS, section 2.3).

Key Numbers

- Emergency: 999; police non-emergency: 101
- Childline: 0800 1111; Report Remove at childline.org.uk (under-18s)
- Your DSL: named in the school's safeguarding policy

Online Evidence: One Rule

- **Ordinary messages or posts a student has already shown you:** note what is relevant (platform, date, who, exact words) in your record. Don't ask to see more or scroll through a phone, especially where messages may be sexual, because they may contain images. Don't log in to accounts, search profiles or investigate, and never transfer anything to a personal device.
- **Nude or semi-nude images of anyone under 18:** don't intentionally view, copy, screenshot, forward, save or delete them. Tell the DSL straight away. If you see one by accident, tell the DSL, ask for support if you need it, and record that it was seen and what you did, without describing the image (UKCIS).
- The DSL decides what happens to devices and content.

Your School's Contacts

This guide is generic. Schools add their own details here, or keep a completed copy with this card, so that anyone responding, including at night, has the routes to hand.

Contact	Name and how to reach them
Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)	
Deputy DSL(s)	
Out-of-hours and boarding on-call safeguarding contact	
How to record a concern (system or form)	
Local authority children's services front door	
Out-of-hours emergency duty team	
LADO (concerns about adults)	
Police: 999 (emergency); 101 (non-emergency)	

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Reference Scenarios · Staff Guide 10

Scenario 10: Nude and Semi-Nude Images Shared Without Consent

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Aligned with: KCSIE 2026 | Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026 | Information Sharing Duty (September 2026) | UKCIS Sharing nudes and semi-nudes (2024) | Protection of Children Act 1978 | Sexual Offences Act 2003, section 66B (Online Safety Act 2023) | RSHE statutory guidance (published July 2025; statutory from September 2026) | NMS for Boarding Schools 2026

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For staff in schools and other settings working with children. You may share it with colleagues. Share the student and parent guides, not this page, with students and families.